



Coaching Manual

Ei4Change

Coaching Manual

Coaching

When a person experiences being coached, their motivation comes from working with a coach who is him / herself an upbeat, positive role model. In this way coaching is a unique way of developing people. Coaches agree that helping coachees to reach their full potential through this approach produces great satisfaction.

What is Coaching?

Coaching is different to training. Coaching draws out rather than puts in. It develops rather than imposes. It reflects rather than directs. Coaching is reactive, flexible and enabling, not prescriptive or instructional. Coaching is non-judgmental, not judgmental.

Coaching is unlocking a person's potential to maximise their own performance. It is helping them to learn rather than teaching them. Coaching draws out rather than puts in. Coaching is interactive, flexible and enabling, not prescriptive or instructional.

Coaching is about getting the very best out of someone and enabling them to make decisions that will improve their life. Coaching techniques are employed in many different and diverse situations, for example: to improve performance at work; climb the career ladder faster; to feel more fulfilled at work; to improve relationships; to learn skills; to gain more meaning to life, or a desire to sort out one's life.

Coaching for business performance may require a fundamental transformation of management style and culture. The inability of so many leaders and their business to move beyond the intent to the practice of culture change remains a major block.

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Coaches work with coachees **to help them find the answers themselves.**

A common feature in all coaching relationships is that **coaching is a two-way process.** Both coach and coachee benefit. Personal development for the coach is a huge aspect of coaching and all coaches find that they themselves grow as well as helping others to do the same.

An excellent coach finds out new things about themselves and is on a continuous learning journey. Coaching entails helping yourself grow and become more self-aware, at the same time, helping others to overcome problems in their lives.

Helping coachees discover where they want to go and helping them to get there is now a proven methodology.

How Coaching Typically Operates

Coaching can often be conducted on the telephone. For several reasons coaching is just as effective over the telephone as it is face-to-face. In fact, many coachees prefer to speak over the telephone. This makes the process very convenient for both coach and coachee offering greater flexibility for people with a busy workload.

Coaching using the telephone offers other obvious advantages:

- coaching can be conducted wherever coach and coachee happen to be anywhere in the world
- there's no travelling time or cost involved
- little preparation needs to be done so telephone coaching sessions can be arranged with minimum notice
- coaching does not need specialised equipment or other expensive overheads

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Coaching Challenges

Coaching is an ongoing process, a method of continuous development and a significant learning experience for coaches and coachees, so it's important to learn from 'mistakes'.

The key to this is realising that these aren't mistakes or failings but are lessons, experiences, and opportunities to learn and develop.

A coach must demonstrate resourcefulness and help people to see that if they think they have failed in the past, this bears no bearing to what they can do in the future.

Listening skills, and resisting the urge to give advice are key attributes and methods of successful coaching and are central to truly helping people find their own direction and solutions.

Listening is the most important ability and behaviour of a coach. This takes patience, tolerance and practice, especially in order to develop real empathic listening techniques.

Communicating fully and expertly is a quality that most good coaches will possess.

Understanding the coachee's needs is also pivotal to the coach-coachee relationship, and is a prerequisite for avoiding difficulties in the relationship and coaching support process.

It is essential that coaches **coach** and do not give advice. There's a huge difference between coaching and advising:

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Coaching is centred around the coachee; whereas advising tends to be based on the beliefs, values and opinions of the advisor. In this respect a coach is most certainly not an advisor. The coach's role, and the coaching concept, is to help the other person find their own solutions - not to have them follow an advisor's recommendations or suggestions.

Qualities of Good Coaching

The qualities required for good coaching are different to managing, training, consultancy, advising:

Listening

In coaching, listening is more important than talking. Through listening, people can be helped to overcome their fears, be offered complete objectivity, and be given undivided attention and unparalleled support. This leads to the intuitive questioning that allows the coachee to explore what is going on for themselves.

Communication skills

Coaching is a two-way process. While listening is crucial, so is being able to interpret and reflect back in ways that remove barriers, pre-conceptions, bias, and negativity. Communicating well enables trust and meaningful understanding on both sides.

Coaches are able to communicate feeling and meaning, as well as content - there is a huge difference. Communicating with no personal agenda, and without judging or influencing, are aspects of the communicating process, especially when dealing with people's personal anxieties, hopes and dreams.

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Good coaching uses communication not to give the coachee the answers, but to help the coachees find their answers for themselves.

Rapport-building

A coach's ability to build rapport with people is vital. Rapport-building is made far easier in because the coach's only focus is the coachee. When a coach supports a person in this way it quite naturally accelerates the rapport-building process.

Motivating and inspiring

Coaches motivate and inspire people. This ability lies within us all. It is borne of a desire to help and support. People who feel ready to help others are normally able to motivate and inspire. When someone receives attention and personal investment this is very motivational and inspirational.

Curiosity, flexibility and courage

Coaching patterns vary; people's needs are different, circumstances and timings are unpredictable, so coaching relationships do not follow a single set formula. Remembering that everyone is different and has different needs is an essential part of coaching. Ultimately, everyone is human - so coaching take human emotions and feelings into account.

Coaching is coachee-led - which means that these emotions have to be tapped into from the very beginning of the coaching process. Having the flexibility to react to people's differences is crucial, along with the curiosity and interest to understand fundamental issues in people's lives.

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The coach's curiosity enables the coachee's journey to be full and far-reaching; both coach and coachee are often surprised at how expectations are exceeded and how much people grow.

All this takes some courage - coaches generally have a strong belief in themselves, a strong determination to do the best they can for their coachees and a belief, or faith, that inherently people are capable of reaching goals themselves.

Coaching Maxims and Principles

Typically good coaches will use and follow these principles:

- Listening is more important than talking
- What motivates people must be understood
- Everyone is capable of achieving more
- A person's past performance is no indication of their future
- People's beliefs about what is possible for themselves are their only limits
- A coach must always provide full support
- Coaches don't provide the answers
- Coaching does not include criticising people
- All coaching is completely confidential
- Some people's needs cannot be met by coaching and this is recognised

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A coach will both support and challenge their coachee. The approach is now fully proven and works for the vast majority of coaching scenarios. In this way coaching is a unique way of developing people.

Underlying Belief within Coaching

The underlying belief in coaching is the intent to help. This requires the belief that the coachee has within them the ability, competence and knowledge that will enable them to effect changes that will result in improvement.

The role of the coach is to draw these out and gain commitment to action.

The Role of the Coachee – Growing Self-Awareness

From the perspective of the coachee, “I am able to control only that of which I am aware. That of which I am not aware controls me. Awareness empowers me.”

The coach is normally able to make a big contribution as a catalyst to the coachee by helping to establish improved self-awareness.

Raising self-awareness, clarifying responsibility and growing self-belief is the goal of a coach.

Raising awareness is the product of focused attention, concentration and clarity. Just like our hearing or eyesight, both of which can be good or poor, there is a big spectrum of awareness. Unlike hearing and eyesight in which the norm is good, the norm of our everyday awareness is typically poor – but it can be raised considerably by focused attention and by practice. Increased awareness gives greater clarity of perception than normal, as does a magnifying glass.

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Responsibility, too, is crucial for high performance. When we accept and choose to take responsibility for our thoughts and actions, our commitment to them rises and so does our performance. Coaching can help clarify responsibility.

In addition, the importance of examining self-limiting beliefs through or during coaching cannot be overemphasized. Our beliefs determine our feelings and actions.

Behaviour

Coaching is about changing feelings and behaviour. Any negative or self-limiting thoughts around an action need to be explored and replaced. Without this, it is unlikely that any real change will occur.

Coaching is about change, about making changes. Mostly, the enemy is habit; habitual actions, habitual thinking and habits that have dug themselves in over time and are hard to move.

Habits are what we do without conscious thought. Clearly then, we become less aware of them as time goes on. This is one of the reasons why raising self-awareness is so important.

The Coaching Toolkit

There are several basic building blocks which together provide the fundamental skills of coaching:-

- Building rapport
- Listening on different levels
- Using intuition
- Effective questions
- Giving supportive feedback

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Rapport

“Rapport is the dance behind communication”

The foundation for all coaching conversations is a feeling of warmth and trust felt between the coach and the coachee. What creates rapport? Where there is a high degree of sameness between two individuals, we build rapport more easily.

Rapport can depend on:-

- Physical appearance / clothes
- Body language / Physical gestures
- Qualities of voice
- Language / Words used
- Beliefs and values

Listening Skills

We can differentiate:-

- Cosmetic listening
- Conversational listening
- Active listening
- Deep listening

Listening is the most important ability and behaviour of a coach. This takes patience, tolerance and practice, especially in order to develop real empathic listening techniques.

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In coaching, listening is more important than talking. Through listening, people can be helped to overcome their fears, be offered complete objectivity, and be given undivided attention and unparalleled support. This leads to the intuitive questioning that allows the coachee to explore what is going on for themselves.

Listening skills, and resisting the urge to give advice are key attributes and methods of successful coaching and are central to truly helping people find their own direction and solutions.

Using Intuition

Study a great coach and you will notice that they often seem to know in what direction to take a conversation. They may choose to ask a question, or make an observation that completely changes what's happening.

Intuition is actually an ability we all have, and one we can develop into a skill. This is one of the great distinguishing characteristics of a coach, and one that makes the coaching role so valuable.

Asking Questions

To be a good coach, you need to be able to ask great questions. Within coaching, a beautifully timed, great question can remove barriers, unlock hidden information and surface potentially life-changing insights. The key is for a coach to maintain an attitude of curiosity and goodwill towards the coachee.

Questions should have a purpose, be simple, open, and neutral. They should influence, but without being controlling and be non-directive rather than directive where possible.

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Good questions may create clarity and explore different perspectives. Poor questions may also narrow options, imply judgement and leave the coachee feeling defensive if used inappropriately.

Constructive, relevant, powerful questions can have a dramatic effect and result in the coachee moving forward with a deeper exploration of an issue, or leaving it in the shallows.

Before engaging with any question, do a mental check of the intention driving it.

Consider:

- *What* do you want to ask?
- *Why* do you want to ask it?
- *What* might the response be?

Irrespective of the type of question you want to ask, it is important to follow these guidance points:

- Ensure that the question is appropriate to the context
- Ask only questions that it is possible to answer
- Keep the question clear, succinct and brief
- Review the trust status of the coaching relationship before asking difficult or challenging questions
- Keep questions open and non-judgmental
- Ask questions that preserve the flow of the conversation

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Coaching Questions and Probes

Question Type	Example
Open-ended probes (for grounding and context)	What do you want to achieve? Can you say more about that?
Neutral probes	Give me an example. Expand upon that, please.
Brief assertions	Sounds interesting Hmmm. Good point.
Pause	"..." (Waiting for an answer)
Reflective probes	Sounds like you are quite annoyed by that. You seem reluctant to discuss...
Summary statements	So, if I understand you correctly, on this occasion this happened.....
Leading questions	Shouldn't we discuss..... That's the best option, isn't it?
Closed questions	How many units did we sell last month? Did you enjoy it?

Ask yourself whether your questions:

- Are detailed or specific enough to avoid misunderstanding?
- Build sequentially from the previous question to keep the whole sequence connected and follow the coaching framework?
- Have clarity of purpose and intention?
- Have the desired effect?

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Asking the right question is at the heart of effective communications and information exchange. By using the right questions in a particular situation, you can improve a whole range of communications skills.

You can

- gather better information and learn more
- build stronger relationships
- manage people more effectively
- help others to learn

You have probably used a number of questioning techniques before in your work and at home. By consciously applying the appropriate kind of questioning, you can gain the information, response or outcome that you want even more effectively.

Questions are a powerful way of:

Learning: By gathering fresh understanding and perspectives from other viewpoints.

Relationship Building: People generally respond positively if you ask about what they do or enquire about their opinions. If you do this in an affirmative way "Tell me what you like best about working here" you will help to build and maintain an open dialogue.

Avoiding misunderstandings: Using questions to seek clarification, particularly when the consequences are significant, will make sure that you avoid jumping to conclusions.

Persuading people: No one likes to be lectured or told what to do. Asking a series of open questions will help others to embrace the reasons behind your point of view.

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Defusing a heated situation: An angry customer, employee or colleague can be reassured by using questions that ask them to go into more detail about their issues. Questions will not only distract them from their emotions but will often help to identify a small practical thing that can be done, which is often enough to make them feel that their concerns have been understood and so they no longer need to be angry.

Questioning skills are a fundamental part of a good leader's toolkit. They help people to reflect and to commit to courses of action that they feel committed to as they feel listened to, understood and empowered to take the action that they need to make a difference.

Tips

Make sure that you give the person you're questioning enough time to respond. You may need to include thinking time before they answer - so don't interpret a pause as a "No comment" and ignore this.

Skillful questioning needs to be matched by careful listening so that you understand what people really mean with their answers.

Your body language and tone of voice can also play a part in the answers you get when you ask questions.

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The GROW Model

Grow

Set goals for the session as well as for the long term. A long term goal could be described as the end goal and shorter term goals could be described as performance goals – that level of performance which will help achieve the end goal.

Aim: Set long term goals

Objective: Agree specific objective of session

Topic: Agree topic for discussion

Useful questions for Goal Setting

- What would you like to get out of this session?
- What would be the best outcome for you from this session?
- What is the topic or issue on which you would like to work?
- In the long term, what is your goal (with this topic / issue)?
- What would be useful steps to identify?

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Reality

This is concerned with exploring the current situation and with objective description and factual answers rather than opinions, judgemental evaluations, prejudices, hopes and fears. The coach needs to encourage the coachee to use descriptive language to reduce the counter effects of self-criticism. Help the coachee avoid vague generalisations and judgemental language like good / bad, success / failure, right / wrong.

Assessment: Invite self-assessment – create self-awareness

Examples: Offer specific examples of feedback

Assumptions: Avoid or check assumptions, discard irrelevant history

Useful Reality questions

- What is the present situation, in more detail?
- What is your concern about it?
- What is your greatest concern?
- How much control do you have over the outcome?
- Does this affect anyone apart from you?
- Who / What actions have you taken so far?
- What were the effects of this?
- What stopped you going any further?
- What barriers will need to be overcome?
- What really is the issue here?
- What's the bottom line?

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Options

At this stage of the coaching we are looking to create and list as many options or alternative courses of action as possible. The quantity is more important at this stage than quality or feasibility. Options need to be identified initially without any expression of preference, and without assumptions, ridicule, censorship, obstacles or completeness. Once the list has been produced specific action steps can be developed.

Range: Cover the full range of options evaluating the benefits and limitations of each one.

Suggestions: Invite suggestions from the coachee. Offer suggestions CAREFULLY.

Choices: Ensure choices are made.

Useful Options questions

- What are the different ways you could approach this?
- What would you do if?
- What would you do if you could start with a blank sheet of paper?
- What else?
- Would you like some suggestions from me?
- What are the advantages and disadvantages of ...?
- Which of these solutions appeals to you most?
- Which would give you the best result?

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Will

At this final coaching phase we are looking to convert the discussion into decision. It is about building an action plan to take the coachee towards the goal. The coachee needs to retain choice and ownership even to the extent of deciding to do nothing.

Action: Commit to action

Obstacles: Identify possible obstacles and how to overcome them. Agree support.

Milestones: Make steps SMART

Useful what Will you do questions

- What are you going to do?
- Which option(s) are you going to select?
- When are you going to do it?
- Will this option meet your goal?
- What are the success criteria for this option?
- What obstacles might you meet?
- Who needs to know about this?
- What support do you need?
- From whom?
- How and when will you get that support?
- What other considerations do you have?
- On a scale of 1 to 10, how certain are you that you will carry out the actions agreed?
- What prevents it being 10?

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The Manager as a Coach

Historically, managers have been selected on the basis of their technical skills and on their ability to get the job done. Research shows that the management of people has a greater effect on productivity and profitability than the combined effects of strategy, quality and technology.

In the last 5 years, there has been an increased appreciation of the need for 'softer skills' and people-oriented skills in the workplace.

Modern managers require excellent communication skills and the ability to deal with diverse employees. Often the best employees seek self-development, self-responsibility and accountability rather than direction and control. They respond well to being coached rather than managed in the traditional style.

But managers have to manage, and may often wish or need to give advice and give instructions. The leadership style most appropriate to managers in this situation is frequently a directive / authoritarian one, where the manager assesses any performance error, identifies corrective action and rewards the employee for implementing the desired improvement. So can a manager, therefore, be a coach at all?

Managers can learn and appropriately use a new, supportive, enabling leadership style that builds trust and induces improved performance in the workplace. Coaching demands the highest qualities of the manager: empathy, integrity and detachment, as well as a willingness to adopt a fundamentally different approach to their staff. The role of the manager as coach extends beyond corrective or remedial actions for performance deficits. Coaching is about performance improvement and so the manager's role involves guiding, developing and encouraging their people.

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Potential and Optimism

To use coaching successfully, we have to adopt a far more optimistic view than usual of the dormant capability of people, all people. We must see people in terms of their future potential, not their past performance.

A coach must think of his / her people in terms of their potential, not their performance. To get the best out of people, we have to believe the best is in there! A coach must demonstrate resourcefulness and help their people to see that if they think they have 'fallen short' in the past, this does not dictate what they can do in the future. It offers managers a new way of relating.

Coaching is an ongoing process, a method of continuous development and a significant learning experience for coaches and coachees. The key to this is realising that there aren't mistakes or failings but only experiences and opportunities to learn and develop.

When managers adopt an enabling approach, the organisation benefits in numerous ways – there is increased employee commitment to the vision and goals of the organisation; self awareness is increased and interpersonal skills are valued and developed; staff turnover is decreased because individuals feel ownership and investment in the company's success; workplace communication is improved.

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Introducing an Enabling Approach

Coaching skills, methodologies, and principles offer another perspective to organisations looking for effective deployment of the skills, knowledge and capabilities of their people, managers and executives. Best practice has demonstrated that an enabling approach provides a positive environment for such an initiative. Without senior managers who value, embrace, support and provide resources for coaching, it is unlikely that isolated coaching partnerships will impact significantly on the business or organisation.

The nature of coaching enables a different and effective approach to developing people's contribution - for example, positive behaviour, integrity, humanity, ethics, mentoring, culture, emotional maturity, etc - which are so vital for the successful performance of modern organisations.

Empowering

It is important to emphasize that coaching is more than just a technique; it is a way of achieving effective results in appropriate situations.

Rather than retaining tight direct control, the manager empowers others to accomplish results on their own initiative. There is still a strong focus on the organisational goals and coaching gives an opportunity to align the individual's goals and commitments with those of the organisation.

By empowering others, setting goals, and collaborating on strategies, the manager taps into the individual's intrinsic motivation. In enabling others, employees become responsible for their own commitments, decisions and actions in the workplace.

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Some managers have yet to develop their coaching skills and may feel they lack the competencies to coach and develop others. In addition to this, some managers have a sense of losing control on the day to day detail. This needs to be balanced by

- The realisation that the manager still maintains overall authority for the outcome
- Building a full understanding of coaching and its appropriate use
- Building the skills to become a great coach

An Integrated Approach to Organisational Development

Coaching skills, methodologies and principles offer a radically new perspective to organisations looking for effective and innovative training and development solutions for their people, managers and executives.

The nature of coaching as a learning and development model enables a different and effective approach to developing traditional 'intangibles' - for example positive behaviour, integrity, humanity, ethics, mentoring, culture, emotional maturity, etc - which are so vital for the successful performance of modern organisations.

"A coaching management style / culture results in getting the job done well for 250 days a year, developing people for 250 days a year and a lot of self-belief."

John Whitmore

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